To the Editors, Small Business Economics

Dear Editors,

I submit "More women owners, or more women working at home on contract? Women's enterprise ownership in India, 2015–16 to 2023–24" for consideration in Small Business Economics. The manuscript is submitted exclusively to the journal and is not under consideration elsewhere.

India's official enterprise surveys report a fast rise in the share of unincorporated non-agricultural enterprises owned by women; the published share of female-owned proprietary establishments rose from 22.9 to 26.2 per cent between 2022–23 and 2023–24 alone. The paper uses the unit-level data of the NSS 73rd round (2015–16) and the Annual Survey of Unincorporated Sector Enterprises 2023–24, reproduces the published estimates, and asks where the new women-owned enterprises are and what they earn. It decomposes the rise by activity, home location and dependence on a contractor, and compares the value added per worker of these enterprises with the earnings women could obtain as casual or self-employed workers, estimated from the Periodic Labour Force Survey 2023–24.

The paper reproduces 13 published statistics from the unit data, the largest gap being 0.45 per cent. It finds that the female-proprietor share rose from 19.5 to 26.3 per cent in a common coverage, driven by changes within activity and location cells, and that the rise does not appear to be driven by home-based contract work as the surveys record it: the share of women's enterprises working mainly for a contractor fell from 31.2 to 17.0 per cent. Instead, home-based enterprises selling on their own account account for 65.3 per cent of the net rise, and 80.1 per cent of women's enterprises generate less value added per worker than 25 days of the casual wage. Ownership counts therefore overstate the growth of remunerative women's entrepreneurship.

The paper builds on work in this journal on the productivity of home-based women-owned firms in India (Bose, 2023) and on gender and credit access (Chaudhuri, Sasidharan and Raj, 2020), and extends it to the post-pandemic period, to trade and services, and to a welfare benchmark. It speaks to the journal's interest in how entrepreneurship is measured and in the economic role of small and informal firms.

Previous work and overlap. No preprint or working-paper version of this manuscript exists. I have a separate manuscript under review that uses the Periodic Labour Force Survey to study the measurement of women's employment; it does not use the enterprise surveys or address this question. I can provide it to the editors on request.

I am the sole author. I have no competing interests and received no funding for this research. Claude (Anthropic) and other AI tools were used to help write and check the analysis code, check the references and draft and edit the text, under my direction. I reviewed and verified all output and take full responsibility for the content.

Sincerely,

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